FAILED REBOOT



After years of decline, the Congress in Bihar has finally pressed the reset button—only to discover it may have rebooted into the same old system. On March 30, when AICC general secretary **K.C. Venugopal** unveiled the list of 53 district presidents, it set off immediate reactions of a "massive social imbalance", with upper castes punching way above their demographic weight. The list seemed curiously out of tune with Rahul Gandhi's sermons on, you guessed it, social imbalances. The state unit, sensing the discord in the ranks, has now requested a revision.

Friendly Foes



Shiv Sena UBT leader **Aaditya Thackeray**'s presence at the birthday party of BJP leader Mohit Kamboj's daughter in Mumbai has created a flutter among party loyalists. Kamboj, a Congress turncoat-turned-aide of CM Devendra Fadnavis, has had a meteoric rise as a real estate developer in Mumbai. He is also said to have played a big role in toppling the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) regime led by Uddhav Thackeray in 2022. So, is the political not personal for the Thackerays anymore? Or are more realignments in store?

GUJARAT CODE



If politics is theatre, **Asaduddin Owaisi** knows exactly where to place the spotlight. With the Gujarat local polls slated this month, the All India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen (AIMIM) chief staged quite an entrance, launching the party's campaign from JP Chowk in Ahmedabad, bang opposite the BJP's former state headquarters. The AIMIM is expanding this time, contesting 539 seats across six municipal corporations, as well as some 60 panchayat seats. In its 2021 debut, it had won 7 seats in Ahmedabad alone, all snatched from the Congress.

Avaneesh Mishra, Prasad Nichenametla, Amitabh Srivastava, Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Jumana Shah

HEALTH WATCH

By **Sonali Acharjee**

DENGUE VACCINES
A SHOT TO PREVENT OUTBREAKS

India may finally be close to getting a dengue vaccine, what public health experts had desperately wanted for years. With dengue cases rising almost every monsoon and cities seeing repeated outbreaks, a vaccine could significantly change how India deals with one of its most persistent seasonal diseases. Japanese drugs manufacturer Takeda Pharma is set to roll out its Qdenga (TAK-003) vaccine in India through a manufacturing partnership with Hyderabad-based Biological E (Bio E). Clinical trials and approval from the health ministry's Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) will, of course, be mandatory. The vaccine is already in use in 40 countries, including the UK, Brazil and those in Europe.

Dengue is spread by the *Aedes aegypti* mosquito and affects millions in India every year, especially in urban areas. Severe dengue can cause bleeding, organ failure, and can be fatal, particularly in children and the elderly. The new dengue vaccines being considered work by training the immune system to recognise all four dengue virus types. Dengue is complicated because a person can be infected multiple times by different strains, and the second infection is often more severe. The vaccine uses weakened or modified virus components, so the body learns to fight the virus before real infection sets in.

If introduced widely, the dengue vaccine could reduce hospitalisations, severity of cases, and pressure on hospitals during monsoon outbreaks—something Indian cities struggle with every year.



FUTURE-READY A hybrid solar cell lab at IIT Bombay